



TABLES FOR TWO

HK Food Court

82-02 45th Ave., Queens

About a year ago, I moved from one Brooklyn neighborhood to another. After several recent trips to the new Elmhurst outpost of HK Food Court (the original is in Flushing), I've been wondering if I shouldn't have relocated to Queens instead. Of course, there are considerations other than eating when deciding where to live, but, at the moment, my difficulty getting there leaves me feeling a little sorry for myself.

Once you've arrived, HK Food Court is an emblem of ease, a fast and comfortable one-stop shop for fulfilling a variety of cravings. A couple of dozen stalls—serving regional Chinese, Thai, Vietnamese, Japanese, and Filipino cuisine—line the perimeter of a windowless but brightly lit box that used to house a pan-Asian grocery store; in the center is cafeteria-style seating for about two hundred, livened up with potted plants.

My most pressing craving is for the hot-and-sour soup from Lao Ma Spicy. The vender specializes in dry pot (like hot pot but brothless, and cooked to order), which is worth having, too.

But the soup is what haunts my daydreams: a large disposable plastic bowl priced irresistibly, at \$4.99, and packed precariously full of glass noodles in an intensely flavorful broth—indeed hot, both in temperature and flavor, scarlet with chili oil, and vinegar-sour. For a few dollars extra, you can add a protein: beef, shrimp balls, Spam. Either way, the final and most crucial ingredients are dry-roasted peanuts with their papery brown skins intact, sweet leaves of steamed bok choy, and an intoxicating spoonful of ground pork, sautéed with tender curls of wood-ear mushroom and pickled radish.

Skewers, too, go twirling through my mind. One evening, at Lan Zhou Ramen, I ordered fat coins of Japanese eggplant—so shellacked in oil that they looked like porcelain yet melted forgivingly in the mouth—and bunches of chives as pliant as seagrass. From Mr. Liu Henan Wide Ramen, one stall over: cubes of fried wheat-bran dough dusted in cumin and a spiral-cut potato.

To say that the tables are communal is an understatement. That evening, a stranger darted over to point at the potato, wanting to know where he could find it. (He was gone before I could tell him that it wasn't quite as good as it looked.) One afternoon, a woman sipped milky tea and took bites from a flaky orange-hued pastry, exposing a dark mash within. My friend inquired as to what it was and where she got it. The dough was made with pumpkin, she explained, the filling sweet black-bean paste—and she had brought it from home. She dug

into a plastic bag for another, insisting that we take it.

I knew what to get at Khao Ka Moo, because I saw many people hunched over the same dish, and, plus, the stall is named for it: *khao ka moo*, otherwise known as stewed pork leg over rice, garnished with a hard-boiled egg and pickled mustard greens and served with a cup of clear pork broth.

I knew what to get at a seafood stall called Chili Boiled Fish, where live ones flopped around in a tank. A friendly cashier with a tattoo on her neck of a lipstick kiss carefully sealed a patterned bowl (for which I paid a five-dollar deposit) with plastic wrap to insure that it stayed hot. That proved unnecessary; it was many minutes before the dish cooled to less than scalding—which didn't stop me from immediately plunging my flimsy spoon into the oily depths to find silky fillets of fish, tender cabbage, and chunks of cucumber, Sichuan peppercorns clinging to all, staining my rice with neon drips.

At Famous Food, three women pinched dough around minced meat and piled Styrofoam plates with slippery steamed dumplings: pork, shrimp, and chive; pork and celery; wontons swimming in chili oil, topped with clumps of sharp raw garlic. In a moment of respite, the women snacked on half-peeled sweet potatoes, holding their leathery skins like ice-cream cones. "Can I order one of those?" I wondered aloud. They shook their heads and laughed. (Dishes \$2–\$35.)

—Hannah Goldfield

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THE TALK OF THE TOWN

COMMENT IMBALANCE OF POWER

In the dazed aftermath of the 2016 election, as a vast portion of the country tried to come to terms with the fact that a fixture of the tabloids and of reality TV would be the next President of the United States, Stephen Bannon, one of Donald Trump's senior advisers, sought to place the event in a historical context. Like Andrew Jackson, Bannon told *The Hollywood Reporter*, "We're going to build an entirely new political movement." Trump, embracing the comparison, hung a portrait of Jackson in the Oval Office. Superficially, the kinship made sense: both Jackson and Trump were wealthy men whose elections signified a populist turn in American politics. Both were ridiculed as uncouth and déclassé, and both saw their colorful marital history dissected in the newspapers. A deeper comparison would also have highlighted the racism associated with their political careers: Jackson owned slaves and directed the removal of Native Americans from their lands; Trump campaigned on a platform of removing people from the nation itself.

President Trump's impeachment trial in the Senate points to another, potentially far more consequential area of commonality between the two Presidents. In 1832, the Supreme Court handed down a decision, in *Worcester v. Georgia*, that effectively prohibited the states from usurping Native Americans' sovereignty over their lands. That conflicted with Jackson's plans, and he responded by saying, in effect, good luck with enforcing that. Jackson's critics saw such willing-

ness to dismiss the authority of a co-equal branch of the government as further evidence that he had no business being in the Oval Office.

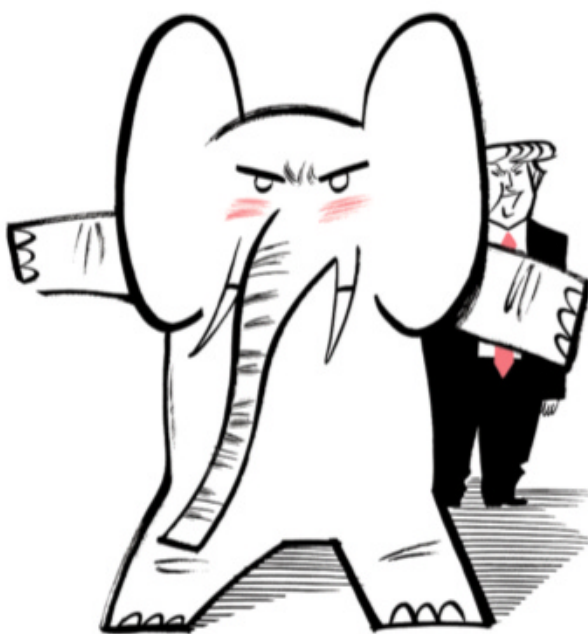
The Trump Administration's strategy for fighting impeachment entails dismissing the authority of the third co-equal branch of government. The White House has steadfastly ignored the House of Representatives' subpoenas to produce documents and witnesses relating to Trump's alleged attempt to strong-arm the Ukrainian government to assist with a ploy to sink Joe Biden's Presidential candidacy. It is not unheard-of for an Administration to stall or only partly comply with subpoenas. (The Republican-led House notably held Attorney General Eric Holder in contempt, in 2012, for not fully complying with subpoenas related to the Department of Justice's Fast and Furious firearms sting operation.) But Trump has refused to comply at all, and congressional Republicans, ignoring one of

their most important duties—executive oversight—have abetted his position.

At the start of trial, in eleven roll-call votes, the Republican majority voted down measures to request relevant documents or to hear from new witnesses regarding the Ukraine scheme. Representative Hakeem Jeffries, one of the House impeachment managers, gave an impassioned speech stating the case for summoning Mick Mulvaney, the acting White House chief of staff, to testify. He also told Jay Sekulow, one of Trump's attorneys, who had questioned why the trial was even taking place, "We are here, sir, because President Trump pressured a foreign government to target an American citizen for political and personal gain." He concluded by quoting a fellow-Brooklynite, the Notorious B.I.G.: "If you don't know, now you know." Biggie notwithstanding, the speech failed to move the Republican caucus.

The votes left open the possibility that witnesses and documents might become available, but only later in the proceedings—a state of affairs that Representative Adam Schiff, the lead House manager, called "ass-backwards." The significance of the votes is twofold: not only did Senate Republicans co-sign the White House's effort to turn the impeachment into a show trial; they reduced the power of the legislative branch to which they themselves belong.

In recent years, short-term thinking has come to define our politics to an alarming degree. In 2016, when Senate Majority Leader Mitch McConnell blocked President Barack Obama's nomination of Merrick Garland to the Supreme Court without so much as a vote,



he seemed not to consider what might happen the next time a Republican President tried to shepherd a nominee through a Democratic Senate. The G.O.P. that has come to support Trump's inflammatory nativism is failing to consider the demographic dead end it faces in alienating rapidly growing numbers of immigrant and minority voters. These decisions were bad for the Party and for judicial integrity. The Republican response to the impeachment is bad for the future of democracy.

It's not difficult to discern what some of the long-term impacts of this short-term thinking may be. Trump's coercive phone conversation with the Ukrainian President, Volodymyr Zelensky, occurred after Attorney General William Barr had miscast the Mueller report as an exonerating of the Trump Administration's alleged contacts with Russians trying to interfere in the 2016 election. Even after the whistle-blower's account of the

Ukraine call emerged, Rudy Giuliani, Trump's unofficial envoy, travelled to that country on his behalf. And, even in the midst of the trial, Trump continues to push a false conspiracy theory that Ukraine, not Russia, interfered in the last election. An acquittal in the Senate would confirm Trump's dangerous idea of an omnipotent Presidency.

In explaining why power was to be disseminated among the three branches of government, Madison wrote, in *Federalist* No. 51, that "ambition must be made to counteract ambition." Thus far, the Senate majority's stance on impeachment can more aptly be described as ambition emboldened by deference. Schiff underscored this problem last week, when he told the senators, "You know you can't trust this President to do what's right for this country. You can trust he will do what's right for Donald Trump. He'll do it now. He's done it before. He'll do it for the next several

months. He'll do it in the election if he's allowed to." An acquittal would set a precedent for a U.S. President to invite foreign intervention in one election, demand it in a subsequent election, and remain in power nonetheless. Earlier this month, it was reported that Russian military hackers had attacked Burisma, the Ukrainian gas company that is at the center of the impeachment debacle. It's reasonable to suspect that they may have been looking for information that could be helpful to Trump's reelection effort.

There is a contrast that Bannon could not have envisioned four years ago. Jackson's reputation was made when, as a general, he defeated the British at the Battle of New Orleans, in the War of 1812. He was revered for his willingness to protect the nation from hostile foreign powers. No such claim can be made for Trump. His Presidency has rendered the country more susceptible to them.

—Jelani Cobb

DEPT. OF HOBBIES LITTLE DRUMMER BOY



When assembling the legal team for his Senate impeachment trial, President Trump called up some old friends: Alan Dershowitz, a lawyer for the late Jeffrey Epstein and the author of "The Case Against Impeaching Trump"; Ken Starr, whom, during Bill Clinton's impeachment trial, Trump referred to as a "lunatic"; and two lawyers who defended the President during the Russia probe, Jane Raskin and Jay Sekulow. "We've got the band back together!" Raskin said to CNN, before the hearings began last week. "Jay is definitely the leader of the band."

It's a familiar role for Sekulow, who, for the past several years, has played drums and rhythm guitar in his own rock group, the Jay Sekulow Band. The Jay Sekulow Band often performs on "Jay Sekulow Live!," a daily syndicated radio show hosted by Jay Sekulow and his son Jordan Sekulow. The group does dad-band covers of classic-rock tunes, and some Christian-tinged originals. Their

version of the Doobie Brothers' "Jesus Is Just Alright" has more than a million views on Facebook. Their original song "Where I Stand" ("Father in Heaven hear our prayer/ Strengthen your souls lost in despair") has fewer. The comments section of the band's Facebook page is a mishmash of true and false: one fan thought that Sekulow was a congressman; another identified him as a born-again Christian and the chief counsel for the American Center for Law and Justice. Another wrote, "Congas need to be up in the mix more but otherwise you guys sound great."

The Jay Sekulow Band specializes in the timely posting of songs that function as commentaries on the news. In October, after the story of Trump's Ukraine phone call broke, Sekulow posted a video of his band performing the R. & B. classic "I Heard It Through the Grapevine." The video opens with a shot of the Capitol, followed by clips of Nancy Pelosi and Adam Schiff talking impeachment, and one of Lindsey Graham complaining that the whole thing is based on hearsay. Cut to the Jay Sekulow Band in its studio (guitars hanging on the walls, Oriental rugs). Sekulow pounds away on the drums in a black T-shirt, his dark hair perfect, separated from the other band members by a glass drum shield. And in

2016, right after Trump tweeted that Hillary Clinton was a "PATHOLOGICAL LIAR" for phumphering about her use of a private e-mail server, Sekulow posted the band playing the Three Dog Night hit "Liar." (Debbie Landers, a fan who is a retired nurse in St. Louis, said, "I do like how he can find a song that matches the kind of folks that he and we as a nation deal with.") The whole band wails on the chorus—"Li-ar!"—with Sekulow crashing the cymbals each time. Visible on his wrist, during closeups, is a Beat-



Jay Sekulow

les edition Raymond Weil watch that has song titles where the numbers should be.

Like Trump's legal team, Sekulow's band was conceived as a sort of supergroup, a C-list Traveling Wilburys. To glam up his legal-pad demeanor, Sekulow recruited several stars from the Christian-rock scene: John Elefante, of the band Kansas (a recent hit: "Pass the Flame"); John Schlitt ("God Is Too Big"), of Head East; and Mark Lee Townsend, of DC Talk, which is a regular on the Jesus Freak Cruise.

"Jay's lineup of superstars is outstanding," Scott Cameron, a fan in California, said over the phone. "I don't know how he brought those guys into the fold. You'd think these guys would be drugged-up rock stars from the seventies who are long gone, but no!" Cameron likes to watch the band's live performances on its Facebook page. "When you see Jay on the drums, he seems very staid," Cameron said.

Vance Jorgensen, a personal-injury lawyer in Iowa and Minnesota who found the band through his love of Head East, said that he has managed to separate the Jay Sekulow Band from its politics. He just likes the songs. "I respect Jay for what he's put together," Jorgensen said. "He's bringing in the actual guys who were doing concert tours back in the late sixties, early seventies. Perhaps as time goes on he'll get a little more comfortable, step out front, do a little singing. Who knows?"

Sekulow did not appear too comfortable in his first week leading Trump's defense in the impeachment trial. He was ridiculed for mischaracterizing the conclusions of the Mueller report and for garbling the articles of impeachment themselves, and he rambled on disjointedly after mishearing a remark by the opposing counsel. "Trump may have hired America's dumbest lawyer in Jay Sekulow," Jonathan Chait wrote, in *New York*. And Chief Justice John Roberts, who is known to be a Bob Dylan man, admonished both legal teams for their childish behavior.

The Jay Sekulow Band is on hiatus during the impeachment trial, but perhaps Cameron, the fan in California, has the right take: "You see Jay in the background, playing the drums, and he loves it to death—but he knows his place back there. He's no Neil Peart."

—Tyler Foggatt

HOLLYWOOD POSTCARD BIG FISH



Five days before Hillary Clinton made headlines last week for dissing Bernie Sanders ("Nobody likes him, nobody wants to work with him," she says in a forthcoming documentary), she went to a Hollywood dinner for a nonprofit whose aim is to "make space for women to be heard." Thirty-four attendees waited eagerly for Clinton in a house belonging to Bozoma Saint John, the chief marketing officer of the talent company En-



Hillary Clinton and Patricia Arquette

deavor, to talk about Vital Voices, the women's-empowerment organization that Clinton helped start in 1997.

Patricia Arquette studied a plaque on Saint John's desk. "Feminist AF!" she read aloud. "That's so good." The previous week, she had urged her Twitter followers not to count Sanders out. (Arquette had no comment on Clinton's Bernie bashing.) Sally Field, in polka dots, admired a framed definition of the word "boss." Arquette eyed the front door, which had just opened. "Oh no," she moaned. "A male."

"Am I, really?" the new arrival asked. It was her brother, David Arquette. The siblings got involved with Vital Voices through David's wife, Christina, whose uncle, Mack McLarty, was Bill Clinton's

first chief of staff. David is often dragged onstage at the organization's events. "I always go up and say, 'I'm sorry, on behalf of men,'" he said.

Alyse Nelson, the C.E.O. of Vital Voices, explained the group's goals. "Our work is very much behind the scenes," she said. She noted that the organization had raised more than six hundred thousand dollars for Malala Yousafzai's education fund but had kept it under wraps. Now they were looking to take some credit. "We are realizing that if we don't tell our own story, we can't scale," Nelson said. "We're better known in India than we are in Indiana."

The guest of honor arrived, and everyone gathered for a photo. A woman shouted, "Press your tongue to the roof of your mouth so that you don't have a double chin!" As the camera flashed, Field yelled, "We have more important things to worry about!" Guests were seated at two long, candlelit tables, and Nelson invited Clinton to sit beside her and explain Vital Voices' genesis. Clinton chose to stand.

"Well, now *I* have to stand," Nelson grumbled. "Even though I have four-inch heels on."

"That was your choice," Clinton said amiably. She wore a houndstooth jacket and sensible shoes.

The two recapped some of the group's greatest hits—protecting Russian journalists, assisting a Cameroonian woman running for office. They announced a Vital Voices headquarters, which will open next year, blocks from the White House. A board member ticked off bleak statistics from the International Monetary Fund. "Only two per cent of C.E.O.s in the financial sector are women," she said. "It feels like we had a moment," after the financial crisis, "but we haven't made very much progress. Do you think we should be feeling optimistic?"

"I do!" Clinton said. She turned to T. D. Jakes, a pastor, for a pep talk. "Bishop Jakes, can you give a short version of the cod and the catfish?"

The short version: in a time before Whole Foods, residents of the East Coast ate a lot of cod. "Much like salmon is popular today," Jakes said. The West Coast wanted in, so cod was put on trains west. "It didn't taste the same," Jakes said. "So they decided to ship it alive, in aquariums. It still didn't have the right consistency or taste." Then they tried

putting some catfish in the tanks, because catfish and cod are natural enemies. When the cod arrived out West, it was fresh. “Somewhere, in every person’s life who’s successful, there’s a catfish they’re chasing,” Jakes concluded.

“Remember that being chased by these catfish, *whoever* they are, should keep us fresh and energized and focussed,” Clinton said. “There’s a real danger right now, because it’s so easy to get discouraged, depressed—to retreat. But that just lets the catfish take over.”

“I have an idea,” the TV host Maria Menounos said. “What if we identify those young Hollywood leaders who, yes, want to be an actress or a musician but also have this crazy passion for social change and don’t know how to do it?”

Field shook her head. “Correct me if I’m wrong, but Hollywood is just so fickle and jaded.”

“Oh, *Sally*,” David Arquette said.

“It’s true!” Field said. “I’ve tried to have fund-raising events in Hollywood, and nobody shows up.”

Talk turned to Vital Voices’ P.R. “It’s nebulous,” Patricia Arquette said. “The story tells the story. Look at Greta. I want to *see* the lady in Cameroon.”

“A great way to get these stories out is to marry Vital Voices with female filmmakers,” Alyssa Milano said. “You can submit them to Sundance.” (The Clinton documentary, “Hillary,” in which she berates a catfish named Bernie, will premiere there this week.)

“You can probably work out a deal with a film festival,” Menounos said. She had a better idea: “Get a deal at Netflix.”

—Sheila Marikar

THE BOARDS MARITAL JUJITSU



Christopher Sieber and Jennifer Simard met twenty-five years ago and complete each other’s sentences in the teasing manner of a married couple. But they’re not married; they’re stage actors, who have costarred in “Shrek the Musical” (Sieber was Lord Farquaad; Simard was the Wicked Witch) and “Annie” (he was Daddy Warbucks; she was Miss Han-

nigan). This spring, in a new Broadway revival of “Company,” the 1970 musical by Stephen Sondheim and George Furth, they will play a married couple named Harry and Sarah—one of five pairs who revolve around the protagonist, a marriage-phobic bachelor named Bobby, who, in the new production, is a marriage-phobic bachelorette named Bobbie.

The revival, which originated in London, has also updated some of the references for 2020. In the original, Sarah is taking a karate class and demonstrates her moves on Harry. In the new version, it’s jujitsu, but she still knocks him to the floor. “I guess you could say we’re codependent,” Simard said of the characters, a few days before rehearsals. “You’re a recovering alcoholic—”

“—who’s still drinking,” Sieber said.

“And I’m an overeater—”

“—who’s still eating.”

The two were at Vitor Shaolin’s Brazilian Jiu Jitsu, a school in midtown, for a beginners’ class. (Barbara Barrie, who played Sarah in the original production, took karate lessons and made the director, Hal Prince, pay for them.) “My husband said, ‘You be careful. You haven’t been moving around lately,’” Sieber said with a laugh. Both actors are married. Sieber’s husband, Kevin Burrows, is the food stylist for “The Wendy Williams Show.” They met nineteen years ago, while acting on Broadway in “Beauty and the Beast.” (“He was the fork, and I was Gaston.”) Simard met her husband, the theatre electrician Brad Robertson, eighteen years ago, on the musical “I Love You, You’re Perfect, Now Change.” In “Company,” the martial-arts scene is interlaced with a song called “The Little Things You Do Together,” about the everyday minutiae that keep marriages healthy. Simard was partial to the line about “looks you misconstrue together.” “Brad and I call it the Disproportionate Response Game,” she said, and acted it out: “‘Honey, those vertical stripes look good!’ ‘Oh, because I look bad in the horizontal ones?’”

They filled out a questionnaire. “‘What would you like to achieve with our program?’” Simard read aloud, then wrote down, “Kick . . . Sieber’s . . . ass.” The school’s manager, Jen Sung, explained the philosophy of Brazilian jujitsu. “It really is a human game of chess,” she said. It was founded by Hélio Gracie, a petite man. “That’s why it’s made for

people who are smaller and can go against bigger people.”

“Perfect!” Simard said. (Sieber towers over her, which would make kicking his ass that much funnier onstage.)

Sung ran through the basics, including the tap, the jujitsu equivalent of crying uncle. “When I tap you, it says, ‘Hey, I know you could seriously hurt me, but I respect your technique enough that I’m going to submit to you.’ And the other person says, ‘I respect that, and I’m going to let you live.’” It seemed like a decent metaphor for marriage, in which knowing each other’s vulnerabilities breeds trust—or mutually assured destruction. “My husband and I are both black belts,” Sung added.

Sieber and Simard changed into blue uniforms, called *gis*, and began stretching. An instructor named Silvio taught them “how to fall” safely: curl into a ball, arms at your side. “Now you’re going to learn how to take somebody down,” he said, and demonstrated a double-leg maneuver, in which you clutch your opponent’s thighs and hook your legs around his knees. Then he showed them a move called “Americana from mount,” in which you wrench your opponent’s arm in an unholy direction until, presumably, you get the tap. Silvio invited Simard to try it on him, and she nervously twisted his elbow. “I’m very flexible,” he assured her.

Next came the rear naked choke, in which you cling to your opponent’s back like a backpack and strangle him with your forearm. Sieber and Simard each took an instructor, and soon the foursome was rolling on the floor. They moved on to self-defense, and the other instructor, Freddy, said, “Maybe we’re in Times Square, there’s a bar. You walk there after work, and some guys have had a rough day.” He showed how to block a punch, then slide in and lift one of those bad boys on your hip, like a fanny pack.

“So someone of my size, in theory, could do that to him?” Simard asked, nodding at Sieber.

“Yeah, because it’s all about the leverage,” Freddy said.

Last, they learned some basic grip defenses—how to pry off someone’s grabby fingers. Simard was giddy. “Forget music rehearsal. We’re doing this. *For hours*.” She added, “The choke hold I’m excited about.” It’s the little things.

—Michael Schulman

GAME FACE BOYS AND GIRLS

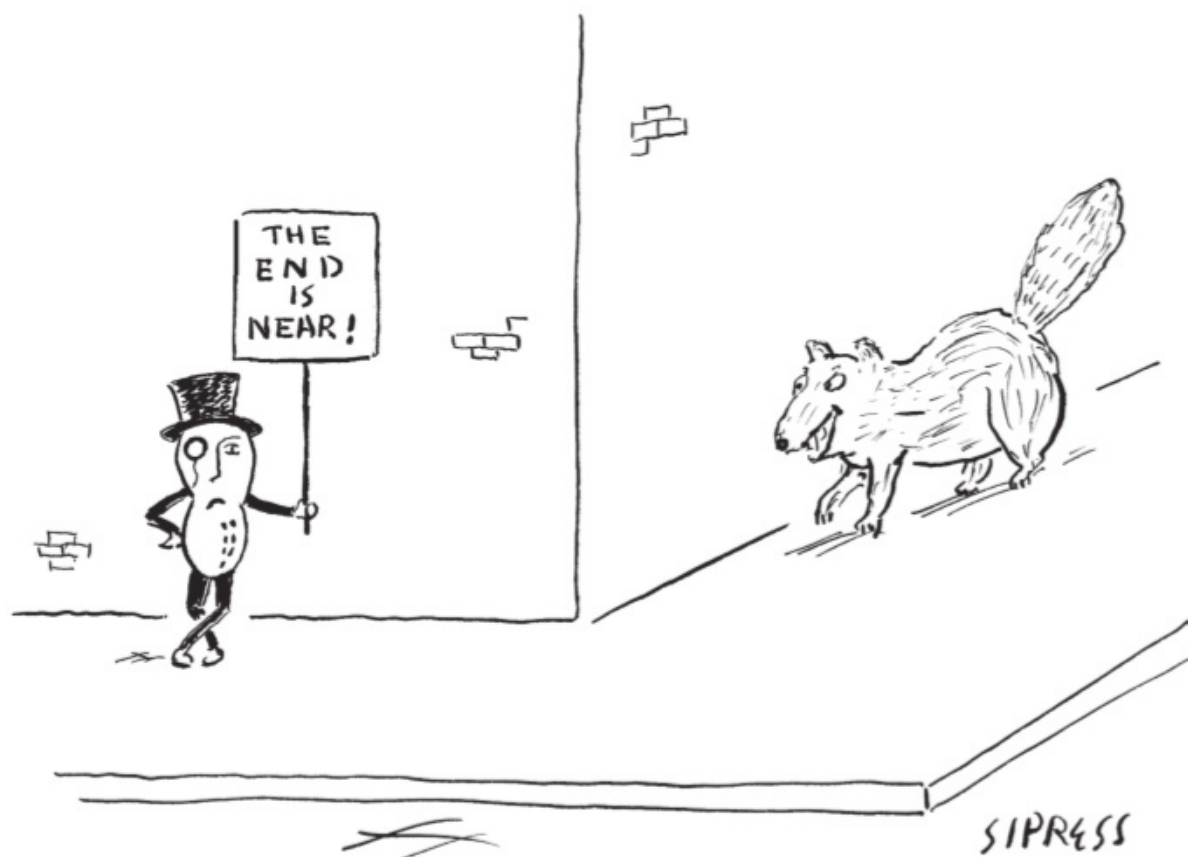


On Sunday, the San Francisco 49ers will face the Kansas City Chiefs in Super Bowl LIV, in Miami. Recently, one state over, several dozen girls gathered at the John Lewis Invictus Academy, in Atlanta, for their own football game. The school was hosting the Jen Welter Girls' Flag Football Camp, a free workshop where kids would "ball out with some of the best," according to the camp's Web site. A tropical storm had relocated the balling to the gym, where about seventy girls and ten boys pulled on red T-shirts printed with the camp's team name, Grrridiron Girls, and logo: a line drawing of a football with long, pointy fingernails where the laces should be.

"I've been playing flag football for a year, just at the park or the schools around me," Ella White, a sixteen-year-old who'd come straight from ballet class, said. She smiled. "There's a lot of estrogen in here."

Shortly after 2 P.M., Jen Welter, dressed in black leggings, a black baseball cap, and a Grrridiron Girls shirt with the sleeves rolled up, addressed the campers. Her long brown hair had been pulled into a ponytail, and thick mascara coated her lashes. "We've got all kinds of battles trying to get girls and women an opportunity to play football," she said. "And we've got to fight natural disasters, too?"

Welter spent more than a decade as a linebacker in women's professional-football leagues before she suited up, in 2014, for a season as a running back with the Texas Revolution, a men's team in the Champions Indoor Football league (official stat line: one game, three carries, -1 yards). The following year, she became the first woman to land an N.F.L. coaching gig (a preseason internship with the Arizona Cardinals). But, when no full-time N.F.L. job materialized, she began teaching at youth camps across the country and discovered that even the coed ones were mostly male. "Nobody was specifically looking to give girls an opportunity to learn football,"



she said. In 2017, she started her camp.

First up, drills. The kids broke into groups and rotated through nine stations that had names like Flag Wars, Dictating Terms, and Around the World. Welter directed Read & React, a fast-moving defensive drill that required running forward, backward, or side to side depending on the command. Her coaching persona was like a cross between Bill Belichick—the gruff head coach of the New England Patriots—and Oprah.

"Pass!" Welter barked. "Run! Pass! Shuffle!"

"That was horrible for me," a girl with pigtails said.

"All of you on defense right now got beat. Why?" Welter asked. "You weren't ready."

"Nobody even noticed that I fell back there," a girl in pink-and-blue Fila sneakers complained.

"I'd love to tell you that you'll never fall down on a football field, but that's simply not the case," Welter said. "All we ask is that you get up and keep going."

Two hours later, the games began. Traffic cones split the gym floor into thirds, and in each section two teams of seven faced off. Although bodies constantly banged and players regularly landed with a loud thud on the hardwood floor, some girls wished for a little *more* contact. "I get put on my butt a lot," Rachel Wayne, the only girl on the Lanier High School varsity football

team, said. (She plays middle linebacker.) "But it's fun. My mom wants me to play in college, but there's part of me that's, like, 'I just want to be normal.'"

White, the ballerina, would like to play tackle. "But my mom won't let me," she said. "She's, like, 'Those concussions! I won't allow it!'"

At five-thirty, the final whistle blew. Everyone gathered for a sendoff from Welter. She talked about diversity and teamwork, and finally brought up the elephant in the room. "Someone asked me once why I'm O.K. with boys coming to girls' camp," she said. "Know why? Girls weren't allowed to play football when I was your age. We gotta be better than the generation before us."

As the crowd cleared out, two boys in Grrridiron Girls shirts stood waiting for their mothers. "It was a good experience because I learned that women don't have a lot of opportunities," an eleven-year-old named Calvin Paul, Jr., said.

"I don't mind playing with the girls," Kaden Mitchell, who is also eleven, said.

"Yeah," Paul said. "Because they have skills."

The feeling wasn't mutual. "When I play football at school, I usually go home because of an injury," Zoë Rolen, who is nine, said, referring to the roughness of the boys on her team. Did they accept her on the gridiron? She shrugged and said, "I don't care what they think."

—Tim Struby

THE FUTURE OF DEMOCRACY

IN EVERY DARK HOUR

In the thirties, democracy's survival was in question. What was our answer?

BY JILL LEPORE



The last time democracy nearly died all over the world and almost all at once, Americans argued about it, and then they tried to fix it. “The future of democracy is topic number one in the animated discussion going on all over America,” a contributor to the *New York Times* wrote in 1937. “In the Legislatures, over the radio, at the luncheon table, in the drawing rooms, at meetings of forums and in all kinds of groups of citizens everywhere, people are talking about the democratic way of life.” People bickered and people hollered, and they also made rules. “You are a liar!” one guy shouted from the audience during a political debate heard on the radio by ten

million Americans, from Missoula to Tallahassee. “Now, now, we don’t allow that,” the moderator said, calmly, and asked him to leave.

In the nineteen-thirties, you could count on the Yankees winning the World Series, dust storms plaguing the prairies, evangelicals preaching on the radio, Franklin Delano Roosevelt residing in the White House, people lining up for blocks to get scraps of food, and democracies dying, from the Andes to the Urals and the Alps.

In 1917, Woodrow Wilson’s Administration had promised that winning the Great War would “make the world safe for democracy.” The peace carved

nearly a dozen new states out of the former Russian, Ottoman, and Austrian empires. The number of democracies in the world rose; the spread of liberal-democratic governance began to appear inevitable. But this was no more than a reverie. Infant democracies grew, toddled, wobbled, and fell: Hungary, Albania, Poland, Lithuania, Yugoslavia. In older states, too, the desperate masses turned to authoritarianism. Benito Mussolini marched on Rome in 1922. It had taken a century and a half for European monarchs who ruled by divine right and brute force to be replaced by constitutional democracies and the rule of law. Now Fascism and Communism toppled these governments in a matter of months, even before the stock-market crash of 1929 and the misery that ensued.

“Epitaphs for democracy are the fashion of the day,” the soon-to-be Supreme Court Justice Felix Frankfurter wrote, dismally, in 1930. The *annus horribilis* that followed differed from every other year in the history of the world, according to the British historian Arnold Toynbee: “In 1931, men and women all over the world were seriously contemplating and frankly discussing the possibility that the Western system of Society might break down and cease to work.” When Japan invaded Manchuria, the League of Nations condemned the annexation, to no avail. “The liberal state is destined to perish,” Mussolini predicted in 1932. “All the political experiments of our day are anti-liberal.” By 1933, the year Adolf Hitler came to power, the American political commentator Walter Lippmann was telling an audience of students at Berkeley that “the old relationships among the great masses of the people of the earth have disappeared.” What next? More epitaphs: Greece, Romania, Estonia, and Latvia. Authoritarians multiplied in Portugal, Uruguay, Spain. Japan invaded Shanghai. Mussolini invaded Ethiopia. “The present century is the century of authority,” he declared, “a century of the Right, a Fascist century.”

American democracy, too, staggered, weakened by corruption, monopoly, apathy, inequality, political violence, hucksterism, racial injustice, unemployment, even starvation. “We do not distrust the future of essential democracy,” F.D.R.

It’s a paradox of democracy that the best way to defend it is to argue about it.

said in his first Inaugural Address, telling Americans that the only thing they had to fear was fear itself. But there *was* more to be afraid of, including Americans' own declining faith in self-government. "What Does Democracy Mean?" NBC radio asked listeners. "Do we Negroes believe in democracy?" W.E.B. Du Bois asked the readers of his newspaper column. Could it happen here? Sinclair Lewis asked in 1935. Americans suffered, and hungered, and wondered. The historian Charles Beard, in the inevitable essay on "The Future of Democracy in the United States," predicted that American democracy would endure, if only because "there is in America, no Rome, no Berlin to march on." Some Americans turned to Communism. Some turned to Fascism. And a lot of people, worried about whether American democracy could survive past the end of the decade, strove to save it.

"It's not too late," Jimmy Stewart pleaded with Congress, rasping, exhausted, in "Mr. Smith Goes to Washington," in 1939. "Great principles don't get lost once they come to light." It wasn't too late. It's still not too late.

There's a kind of likeness you see in family photographs, generation after generation. The same ears, the same funny nose. Sometimes now looks a lot like then. Still, it can be hard to tell whether the likeness is more than skin deep.

In the nineteen-nineties, with the end of the Cold War, democracies grew more plentiful, much as they had after the end of the First World War. As ever, the infant-mortality rate for democracies was high: baby democracies tend to die in their cradles. Starting in about 2005, the number of democracies around the world began to fall, as it had in the nineteen-thirties. Authoritarians rose to power: Vladimir Putin in Russia, Recep Tayyip Erdoğan in Turkey, Viktor Orbán in Hungary, Jarosław Kaczyński in Poland, Rodrigo Duterte in the Philippines, Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil, and Donald J. Trump in the United States.

"American democracy," as a matter of history, is democracy with an asterisk, the symbol A-Rod's name would need if he were ever inducted into the Hall of Fame. Not until the 1964 Civil

Rights Act and the 1965 Voting Rights Act can the United States be said to have met the basic conditions for political equality requisite in a democracy. All the same, measured not against its past but against its contemporaries, American democracy in the twenty-first century is withering. The Democracy Index rates a hundred and sixty-seven countries, every year, on a scale that ranges from "full democracy" to "authoritarian regime." In 2006, the U.S. was a "full democracy," the seventeenth most democratic nation in the world. In 2016, the index for the first time rated the United States a "flawed democracy," and since then American democracy has gotten only more flawed. True, the United States still doesn't have a Rome or a Berlin to march on. That hasn't saved the nation from misinformation, tribalization, domestic terrorism, human-rights abuses, political intolerance, social-media mob rule, white nationalism, a criminal President, the nobbling of Congress, a corrupt Presidential Administration, assaults on the press, crippling polarization, the undermining of elections, and an epistemological chaos that is the only air that totalitarianism can breathe.

Nothing so sharpens one's appreciation for democracy as bearing witness to its demolition. Mussolini called Italy and Germany "the greatest and soundest democracies which exist in the world today," and Hitler liked to say that, with Nazi Germany, he had achieved a "beautiful democracy," prompting the American political columnist Dorothy Thompson to remark of the Fascist state, "If it is going to call itself democratic we had better find another word for what we have and what we want." In the nineteen-thirties, Americans didn't find another word. But they did work to decide what they wanted, and to imagine and to build it. Thompson, who had been a foreign correspondent in Germany and Austria and had interviewed the Führer, said, in a column that reached eight million readers, "Be sure you know what you prepare to defend."

It's a paradox of democracy that the best way to defend it is to attack it, to ask more of it, by way of criticism, protest, and dissent. American democracy in the nineteen-thirties had plenty of critics, left and right, from Mexican-

Americans who objected to a brutal regime of forced deportations to businessmen who believed the New Deal to be unconstitutional. W.E.B. Du Bois predicted that, unless the United States met its obligations to the dignity and equality of all its citizens and ended its enthrallment to corporations, American democracy would fail: "If it is going to use this power to force the world into color prejudice and race antagonism; if it is going to use it to manufacture millionaires, increase the rule of wealth, and break down democratic government everywhere; if it is going increasingly to stand for reaction, fascism, white supremacy and imperialism; if it is going to promote war and not peace; then America will go the way of the Roman Empire."

The historian Mary Ritter Beard warned that American democracy would make no headway against its "ruthless enemies—war, fascism, ignorance, poverty, scarcity, unemployment, sadistic criminality, racial persecution, man's lust for power and woman's miserable trailing in the shadow of his frightful ways"—unless Americans could imagine a future democracy in which women would no longer be barred from positions of leadership: "If we will not so envisage our future, no Bill of Rights, man's or woman's, is worth the paper on which it is printed."

If the United States hasn't gone the way of the Roman Empire and the Bill of Rights is still worth more than the paper on which it's printed, that's because so many people have been, ever since, fighting the fights Du Bois and Ritter Beard fought. There have been wins and losses. The fight goes on.

Could no system of rule but extremism hold back the chaos of economic decline? In the nineteen-thirties, people all over the world, liberals, hoped that the United States would be able to find a middle road, somewhere between the malignity of a state-run economy and the mercilessness of laissez-faire capitalism. Roosevelt campaigned in 1932 on the promise to rescue American democracy by way of a "new deal for the American people," his version of that third way: relief, recovery, and reform. He won forty-two of forty-eight states, and trounced the incumbent, Herbert Hoover, in the Electoral College 472 to 59. Given the national emergency

in which Roosevelt took office, Congress granted him an almost entirely free hand, even as critics raised concerns that the powers he assumed were barely short of dictatorial.

New Dealers were trying to save the economy; they ended up saving democracy. They built a new America; they told a new American story. On New Deal projects, people from different parts of the country labored side by side, constructing roads and bridges and dams, everything from the Lincoln Tunnel to the Hoover Dam, joining together in a common endeavor, shoulder to the wheel, hand to the forge. Many of those public-works projects, like better transportation and better electrification, also brought far-flung communities, down to the littlest town or the remotest farm, into a national culture, one enriched with new funds for the arts, theatre, music, and storytelling. With radio, more than with any other technology of communication, before or since, Americans gained a sense of their shared suffering, and shared ideals: they listened to one another's voices.

This didn't happen by accident. Writers and actors and directors and broadcasters made it happen. They dedicated themselves to using the medium to bring people together. Beginning in 1938, for instance, F.D.R.'s Works Progress Administration produced a twenty-six-week radio-drama series for CBS called

"Americans All, Immigrants All," written by Gilbert Seldes, the former editor of *The Dial*. "What brought people to this country from the four corners of the earth?" a pamphlet distributed to schoolteachers explaining the series asked. "What gifts did they bear? What were their problems? What problems remain unsolved?" The finale celebrated the American experiment: "The story of magnificent adventure! The record of an unparalleled event in the history of mankind!"

There is no twenty-first-century equivalent of Seldes's "Americans All, Immigrants All," because it is no longer acceptable for a serious artist to write in this vein, and for this audience, and for this purpose. (In some quarters, it was barely acceptable even then.) Love of the ordinary, affection for the common people, concern for the commonweal: these were features of the best writing and art of the nineteen-thirties. They are not so often features lately.

Americans reelected F.D.R. in 1936 by one of the widest margins in the country's history. American magazines continued the trend from the twenties, in which hardly a month went by without their taking stock: "Is Democracy Doomed?" "Can Democracy Survive?" (Those were the past century's versions of more recent titles, such as "How Democracy Ends," "Why Liberalism Failed," "How the Right Lost Its Mind,"

and "How Democracies Die." The same ears, that same funny nose.) In 1934, the *Christian Science Monitor* published a debate called "Whither Democracy?," addressed "to everyone who has been thinking about the future of democracy—and who hasn't." It staked, as adversaries, two British scholars: Alfred Zimmern, a historian from Oxford, on the right, and Harold Laski, a political theorist from the London School of Economics, on the left. "Dr. Zimmern says in effect that where democracy has failed it has not been really tried," the editors explained. "Professor Laski sees an irrepressible conflict between the idea of political equality in democracy and the fact of economic inequality in capitalism, and expects at least a temporary resort to Fascism or a capitalistic dictatorship." On the one hand, American democracy is safe; on the other hand, American democracy is not safe.

Zimmern and Laski went on speaking tours of the United States, part of a long parade of visiting professors brought here to prognosticate on the future of democracy. Laski spoke to a crowd three thousand strong, in Washington's Constitution Hall. "LASKI TELLS HOW TO SAVE DEMOCRACY," the *Washington Post* reported. Zimmern delivered a series of lectures titled "The Future of Democracy," at the University of Buffalo, in which he warned that democracy had been undermined by a new aristocracy of self-professed experts. "I am no more ready to be governed by experts than I am to be governed by the ex-Kaiser," he professed, expertly.

The year 1935 happened to mark the centennial of the publication of Alexis de Tocqueville's "Democracy in America," an occasion that elicited still more lectures from European intellectuals coming to the United States to remark on its system of government and the character of its people, close on Tocqueville's heels. Heinrich Brüning, a scholar and a former Chancellor of Germany, lectured at Princeton on "The Crisis of Democracy"; the Swiss political theorist William Rappard gave the same title to a series of lectures he delivered at the University of Chicago. In "The Prospects for Democracy," the Scottish historian and later BBC radio quiz-show panelist Denis W. Brogan offered little but gloom: "The defenders of



"What the hell was he thinking?"

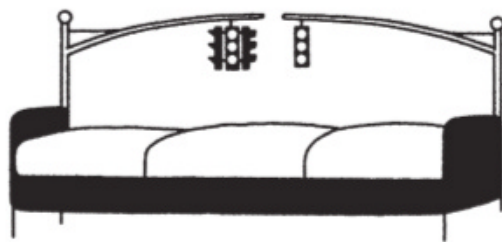
democracy, the thinkers and writers who still believe in its merits, are in danger of suffering the fate of Aristotle, who kept his eyes fixedly on the city-state at a time when that form of government was being reduced to a shadow by the rise of Alexander's world empire." Brogan hedged his bets by predicting the worst. It's an old trick.

The endless train of academics were also called upon to contribute to the nation's growing number of periodicals. In 1937, *The New Republic*, arguing that "at no time since the rise of political democracy have its tenets been so seriously challenged as they are today," ran a series on "The Future of Democracy," featuring pieces by the likes of Bertrand Russell and John Dewey. "Do you think that political democracy is now on the wane?" the editors asked each writer. The series' lead contributor, the Italian philosopher Benedetto Croce, took issue with the question, as philosophers, thankfully, do. "I call this kind of question 'meteorological,'" he grumbled. "It is like asking, 'Do you think that it is going to rain today? Had I better take my umbrella?'" The trouble, Croce explained, is that political problems are not external forces beyond our control; they are forces within our control. "We need solely to make up our own minds and to act."

Don't ask whether you need an umbrella. Go outside and stop the rain.

Here are some of the sorts of people who went out and stopped the rain in the nineteen-thirties: schoolteachers, city councillors, librarians, poets, union organizers, artists, precinct workers, soldiers, civil-rights activists, and investigative reporters. They knew what they were prepared to defend and they defended it, even though they also knew that they risked attack from both the left and the right. Charles Beard (Mary Ritter's husband) spoke out against the newspaper tycoon William Randolph Hearst, the Rupert Murdoch of his day, when he smeared scholars and teachers as Communists. "The people who are doing the most damage to American democracy are men like Charles A. Beard," said a historian at Trinity College in Hartford, speaking at a high school on the subject of "Democracy and the Future," and warning against

reading Beard's books—at a time when Nazis in Germany and Austria were burning "un-German" books in public squares. That did not exactly happen here, but in the nineteen-thirties four of five American superintendents of schools recommended assigning only those U.S. history textbooks which "omit any facts likely to arouse in the minds of the students question or doubt concerning the justice of our social order



and government." Beard's books, God bless them, raised doubts.

Beard didn't back down. Nor did W.P.A. muralists and artists, who were subject to the same attack. Instead, Beard took pains to point out that Americans liked to think of themselves as good talkers and good arguers, people with a particular kind of smarts. Not necessarily book learning, but street smarts—reasonableness, open-mindedness, level-headedness. "The kind of universal intellectual prostration required by Bolshevism and Fascism is decidedly foreign to American 'intelligence,'" Beard wrote. Possibly, he allowed, you could call this a stubborn independence of mind, or even mulishness. "Whatever the interpretation, our wisdom or ignorance stands in the way of our accepting the totalitarian assumption of Omniscience," he insisted. "And to this extent it contributes to the continuance of the arguing, debating, never-settling—anything—finally methods of political democracy." Maybe that was whistling in the dark, but sometimes a whistle is all you've got.

The more argument the better is what the North Carolina-born George V. Denny, Jr., was banking on, anyway, after a neighbor of his, in Scarsdale, declared that he so strongly disagreed with F.D.R. that he never listened to him. Denny, who helped run something called the League for Political Education, thought that was nuts. In 1935, he launched "America's Town Meeting of the Air,"

an hour-long debate program, broadcast nationally on NBC's Blue Network. Each episode opened with a town crier ringing a bell and hollering, "Town meeting tonight! Town meeting tonight!" Then Denny moderated a debate, usually among three or four panelists, on a controversial subject (Does the U.S. have a truly free press? Should schools teach politics?), before opening the discussion up to questions from an audience of more than a thousand people. The debates were conducted at a lecture hall, usually in New York, and broadcast to listeners gathered in public libraries all over the country, so that they could hold their own debates once the show ended. "We are living today on the thin edge of history," Max Lerner, the editor of *The Nation*, said in 1938, during a "Town Meeting of the Air" debate on the meaning of democracy. His panel included a Communist, an exile from the Spanish Civil War, a conservative American political economist, and a Russian columnist. "We didn't expect to settle anything, and therefore we succeeded," the Spanish exile said at the end of the hour, offering this definition: "A democracy is a place where a 'Town Meeting of the Air' can take place."

No one expected anyone to come up with an undisputable definition of democracy, since the point was disputation. Asking people about the meaning and the future of democracy and listening to them argue it out was really only a way to get people to stretch their civic muscles. "Democracy can only be saved by democratic men and women," Dorothy Thompson once said. "The war against democracy begins by the destruction of the democratic temper, the democratic method and the democratic heart. If the democratic temper be exacerbated into wanton unreasonableness, which is the essence of the evil, then a victory has been won for the evil we despise and prepare to defend ourselves against, even though it's 3,000 miles away and has never moved."

The most ambitious plan to get Americans to show up in the same room and argue with one another in the nineteen-thirties came out of Des Moines, Iowa, from a one-eyed former bricklayer named John W. Studebaker, who had become the superintendent of the city's schools. Studebaker, who after the

Second World War helped create the G.I. Bill, had the idea of opening those schools up at night, so that citizens could hold debates. In 1933, with a grant from the Carnegie Corporation and support from the American Association for Adult Education, he started a five-year experiment in civic education.

The meetings began at a quarter to eight, with a fifteen-minute news update, followed by a forty-five-minute lecture, and thirty minutes of debate. The idea was that “the people of the community of every political affiliation, creed, and economic view have an opportunity to participate freely.” When Senator Guy Gillette, a Democrat from Iowa, talked about “Why I Support the New Deal,” Senator Lester Dickinson, a Republican from Iowa, talked about “Why I Oppose the New Deal.” Speakers defended Fascism. They attacked capitalism. They defended capitalism. Within the first nine months of the program, thirteen thousand of Des Moines’s seventy-six thousand adults had attended a forum. The program got so popular that in 1934 F.D.R. appointed Studebaker the U.S. Commissioner of Education and, with the eventual help of Eleanor Roosevelt, the program became a part of the New Deal, and received federal funding. The federal forum program started out in ten test sites—from Orange County, California, to Sedgwick County, Kansas, and Pulaski County, Arkansas. It came to include almost five hundred forums in forty-three states and involved two and a half million Americans. Even people who had steadfastly predicted the demise of democracy participated. “It seems to me the only method by which we are going to achieve democracy in the United States,” Du Bois wrote, in 1937.

The federal government paid for it, but everything else fell under local control, and ordinary people made it work, by showing up and participating. Usually, school districts found the speakers and decided on the topics after collecting ballots from the community. In some parts of the country, even in rural areas, meetings were held four and five times a week. They started in schools and spread to Y.M.C.A.s and Y.W.C.A.s, labor halls, libraries, settlement houses, and businesses, during lunch hours.

Many of the meetings were broadcast by radio. People who went to those meetings debated all sorts of things:

Should the Power of the Supreme Court Be Altered?
Do Company Unions Help Labor?
Do Machines Oust Men?
Must the West Get Out of the East?
Can We Conquer Poverty?
Should Capital Punishment Be Abolished?
Is Propaganda a Menace?
Do We Need a New Constitution?
Should Women Work?
Is America a Good Neighbor?
Can It Happen Here?

These efforts don’t always work. Still, trying them is better than talking about the weather, and waiting for someone to hand you an umbrella.

When a terrible hurricane hit New England in 1938, Dr. Lorine Pruette, a Tennessee-born psychologist who had written an essay called “Why Women Fail,” and who had urged F.D.R. to name only women to his Cabinet, found herself marooned at a farm in New Hampshire with a young neighbor, sixteen-year-old Alice Hooper, a high-school sophomore. Waiting out the storm, they had nothing to do except listen to the news, which, needless to say, concerned the future of democracy. Alice asked Pruette a question: “What is it everyone on the radio is talking about—what is this democracy—what does it mean?” Somehow, in the end, NBC arranged a coast-to-coast broadcast, in which eight prominent thinkers—two ministers, three professors, a former ambassador, a poet, and a journalist—tried to explain to Alice the meaning of democracy. American democracy had found its “Yes, Virginia, there is a Santa Claus” moment, except that it was messier, and more interesting, because those eight people didn’t agree on the answer. Democracy, Alice, is the darnedest thing.

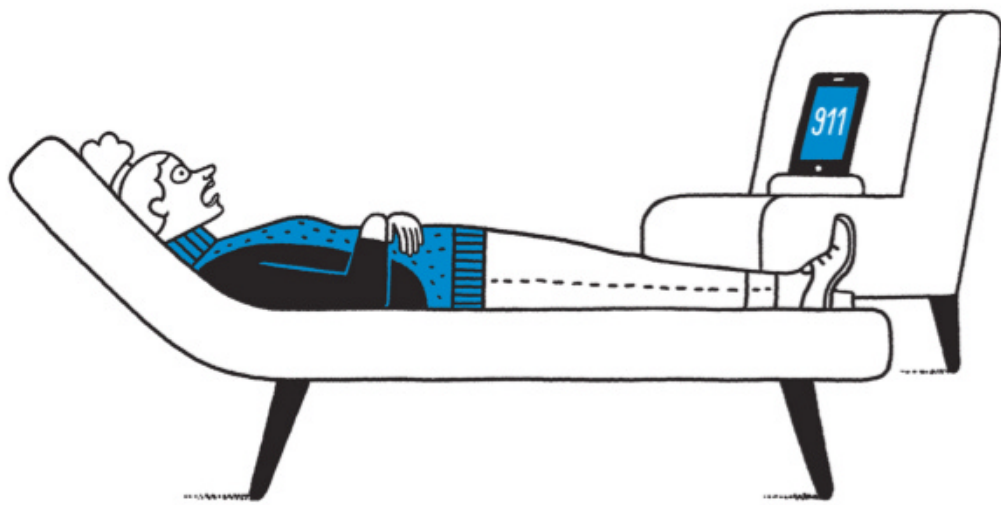
That broadcast was made possible by the workers who brought electricity to rural New Hampshire; the legislators who signed the 1934 federal Communications Act, mandating public-interest broadcasting; the executives at NBC who decided that it was important to run this program; the two ministers, the three professors, the former ambassador, the poet, and the journalist who gave their time, for free, to a public forum, and agreed to disagree

without acting like asses; and a whole lot of Americans who took the time to listen, carefully, even though they had plenty of other things to do. Getting out of our current jam will likely require something different, but not entirely different. And it will be worth doing.

A decade-long debate about the future of democracy came to a close at the end of the nineteen-thirties—but not because it had been settled. In 1939, the World’s Fair opened in Queens, with a main exhibit featuring the saga of democracy and a chipper motto: “The World of Tomorrow.” The fairgrounds included a Court of Peace, with pavilions for every nation. By the time the fair opened, Czechoslovakia had fallen to Germany, though, and its pavilion couldn’t open. Shortly afterward, Edvard Beneš, the exiled President of Czechoslovakia, delivered a series of lectures at the University of Chicago on, yes, the future of democracy, though he spoke less about the future than about the past, and especially about the terrible present, a time of violently unmoored traditions and laws and agreements, a time “of moral and intellectual crisis and chaos.” Soon, more funereal bunting was brought to the World’s Fair, to cover Poland, Belgium, Denmark, France, Luxembourg, and the Netherlands. By the time the World of Tomorrow closed, in 1940, half the European hall lay under a shroud of black.

The federal government stopped funding the forum program in 1941. Americans would take up their debate about the future of democracy, in a different form, only after the defeat of the Axis. For now, there was a war to fight. And there were still essays to publish, if not about the future, then about the present. In 1943, E. B. White got a letter in the mail, from the Writers’ War Board, asking him to write a statement about “The Meaning of Democracy.” He was a little weary of these pieces, but he knew how much they mattered. He wrote back, “Democracy is a request from a War Board, in the middle of a morning in the middle of a war, wanting to know what democracy is.” It meant something once. And, the thing is, it still does. ♦

For more from our Future of Democracy series, visit newyorker.com/democracy.



HELLO, 911?

BY SAMANTHA IRBY

Hello, 911? There's a middle-aged dad standing next to the yogurts in Trader Joe's actively strumming a guitar and trying to make meaningful eye contact with every harried person trying to get a box of Pastry Pups on a dismal Saturday afternoon, and everyone other than me seems to be maintaining a relaxed and happy exterior despite the fact that this is terribly embarrassing and he is singing Bob Marley. Please get me out of here. All I wanted was a bag of reasonably priced shelled nuts sold to me by a relatively attractive retired shoe salesman in a faded Hawaiian shirt. Is that really too much to fucking ask?

Hello, 911? I am the first person at this party.

Hello, 911? I've been lying awake for an hour each night for the past eight months, reliving a two-second awkward experience I had in front of a casual acquaintance three years ago.

Hello, 911? Is some invisible force going to push me down this flight of stairs?

Hello, 911? I was watching that show "Greenleaf," on the Oprah network, and these two characters were riding in a car and having a passionate conversation, and dude turned to lady and I was gripped with what can only be described as stomach-churning panic as my entire body clenched in antici-

pation of the car jumping the curb and crashing through the plate-glass window of a laundromat, because the dude took his eyes entirely off the road for at least twelve seconds. When was the first movie made? 1888? And, after all those years of practice, people still can't film a realistic conversation in a moving car? The driver's eyes need to be on the Toyota in front of him, Oprah Winfrey. I'm going to have a fucking stroke.

Hello, 911? This takeout place doesn't have online ordering.

Hello, 911? Which line is moving faster, the one I'm in or that other line, and do you think I should switch? Does it matter? It's not like I have anywhere to be, but just standing here makes me feel like my organs are going to burst out of my skin. I can't prove it, but I think this line is moving incrementally slower. Why does that make me feel like I'm losing a race? Should I just stay where I am, or do you think it's O.K. if I ease over to Lane 8 in a way that silently telegraphs to the check-out girl, "I'm not mad, just having an inexplicable panic attack, please ignore me"? If I move to that other line, will the Target gods smite me by throwing a clearance-rack shirt with a missing price tag into that lady's cart? Why did I even come here?

Hello, 911? What if I fall asleep on this bus?

Hello, 911? That lady caught me taking a selfie and walked away before I could convincingly pretend to be holding my phone at this angle for some other reason.

Hello, 911? It's eleven-thirty at night and I've got an important meeting (LOL) tomorrow morning at nine-thirty. I set my alarm for eight. That should give me plenty of time, right? Google Maps says it's probably going to take seventeen minutes to get there from my hotel, barring any major traffic, but what if the Lyft driver is late? Alternatively, what if the doorman can't find a cab? I'm planning to go down at nine. Does that leave enough time for me to get eggs from room service? But they run late sometimes, right? Should I risk it? It's midnight now and I think I'll be hungry in the morning, but what if I'm not? Then I'm stuck waiting for eggs I don't want. Maybe I should set my alarm for eight-thirty. I definitely want to sleep off this Xanax, but does that give me enough time to take an actual crevice-cleaning, hair-washing shower? Should I be honest about who I really am as a person and factor in twenty minutes of bedside-sitting-and-staring-into-space time? It's twelve-thirty, but to be safe I'm going to set the alarm for seven-thirty. Should I attempt to impress these people with eye makeup, or do they not care because they are serious businesspersons? Let me just go ahead and set my phone for 6:55, so I have plenty of time to contour and blend (i.e., totally fuck it up and wipe it all off while crying). Since I'm up, it wouldn't hurt to iron my pants, just in case I can't hide my legs under a table. Why does everyone want to "meet" on couches these days? An electric chair would be more relaxing. Wait a minute—it's already one o'clock?!

Hello, 911? My friend just left me a voice mail.

Hello, 911? My brain is a prison, and anxiety is the warden. I am besieged by an undeniable urge to peel off my skin like the layers of an onion until death claims me and I find relief in its cool embrace, and I know it took me a long time to finally call and I'm not a hundred per cent sure that this qualifies as an emergency, but I think I've reached my limit and I might need some help.

O.K., sure, I'll hold. ♦